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“I believe that in the next 20 years... Indian consumerism will rise and there will be significant opportunities for businesses like aviation”

SANJEEV KRISHAN
CHAIRPERSON, PwC IN INDIA

SZ: How would India's aviation and airlines benefit from the Jewar airport?

VD: Let me respond not just on Jewar but also on other airports in general... Let me also talk about transportation and how important it is in facilitating a country's/ city's/state's growth. And the reason I say transportation is because it applies to highway infrastructure, local transportation... to any form of transportation. Without transportation, you can't have the kind of economic growth that you want. Whether it's Jewar or Navi Mumbai, it's not just the benefit to airlines... it's going to benefit consumers,

businesses, and enable India's economic engine. Singapore built its entire economy on the back of Singapore Airlines. Dubai has built its economy on the backs of Emirates... **States and countries are built on the back of strong transportation infrastructure of every kind. And that's the beauty of the investments that are being made in airports today.**

SK: Any kind of infrastructure development is not only necessary, but critical for inclusive development of India. The UDAN scheme is encouraging aspirational India. I think it is going to create a huge amount of development and local employment.

SZ: Rakesh Jhunjhunwala had the knack to pick winners and invested in you. How did that come about?

VD: The late, great Rakesh Jhunjhunwala was an amazing human being. We were introduced by somebody else. It took only a short amount of time to convince him that this was a good investment because he was very intuitive... It didn't take him long to believe that this was the right time to start the airline because he believed in the India growth story more than anyone. And the rest is history.

Treating our employees with dignity and respect and making sure that we build an employee-centric company was important to him. Making sure that while we focussed on our cost structure, we didn't lose sight of empathy with our customers. And this is sort of the ethos with which we live.

SZ: Jhunjhunwala was also someone who was very focussed on the bottom line? Did you have any discussions on a future listing?

VD: Not prominently. The reason is as you know, Rakesh was a long-term investor... Does anyone think about when we will list the company and take it public? Yes, because, having a publicly listed company gives you access to pools of capital that allow you to do bigger and greater things... but that was not anywhere near the central elements of our conversation. Our focus is to get the fundamentals right and make sure we have an on-time and reliable airline.

SZ: How do you achieve this?

VD: By focussing on the fundamentals. First, you say clearly to our 4,500-plus employees that we will be India's most on-time airline, because without them, you can't achieve it... In aviation, you need everyone humming and pointed in the right direction. **BT**

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